THE SAHYADRI LEGACY

Forest Conservation, the Ajnyapatra, and the Future of Maharashtra's Historic Forts

FORESTS • FORTS • RESPONSIBLE DEVELOPMENT

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A Maharashtra-focused study of historical environmental principles, the Sahyadri landscape, and fort conservation.

Contents

01	Executive Summary
02	1. Introduction
03	2. Objectives and Method
04	3. The Sahyadri: A Living Ecological and Historical Landscape
05	4. Case Study: Saidongar-1 and the Karjat Tree-Felling Controversy
06	5. The Ajnyapatra: A Historical Principle of Responsible Resource Use
07	6. Why Maharashtra's Historic Forts Matter
08	7. Important Forts: Heritage and Conservation Priorities
09	8. What Responsible Fort Development Should Look Like
10	9. A Practical Framework: Forests, Forts and Communities
11	10. Recommendations
12	11. Conclusion
13	References and Further Reading

The central argument

> ***"A tree can be cut in minutes, but a forest takes generations to build. A fort can be repaired, but its historical setting cannot always be recreated."***

This report asks how Maharashtra can pursue necessary development while protecting ecological systems, community rights, and the historic landscapes that give its forts meaning.

Executive Summary

This report argues that Maharashtra should treat forests, historic forts, and local communities as connected parts of one heritage landscape. It examines the tree-felling controversy associated with the Saidongar-1 pumped-storage project in Karjat, the environmental principles described in the Ajnyapatra, and the urgent need for well-planned conservation of Maharashtra's forts.

A key historical source is the Ajnyapatra, written around 1715–1716 by Ramchandrapant Amatya under the authority of Chhatrapati Sambhaji II. It contains instructions about responsible timber use and protecting valuable trees that people had nurtured. This is a significant example of environmental and social thinking in Maratha statecraft. The report does not treat it as a blanket ban on tree cutting; instead, it examines the need to weigh resource use against long-term ecological and community costs.

The report recommends transparent environmental decisions, independent ecological assessment, genuine consultation with affected communities, scientific fort conservation, sustainable tourism, and public monitoring of restoration and tree-planting commitments.

1. Introduction

Maharashtra's identity is inseparable from the Sahyadri range, its forests, and its forts. Hill forts were not built in isolation from nature: cliffs, ridgelines, passes, water sources, forests, and coastal approaches all shaped their defence and use. The landscape is therefore part of the history, not merely the background.

Maharashtra faces a difficult but necessary task: developing infrastructure and reliable energy while protecting forests, water systems, wildlife, livelihoods, and cultural heritage. The central question is not whether development should happen, but how to assess its full costs, alternatives, and long-term consequences before decisions become irreversible.

2. Objectives and Method

This report aims to: (1) explain the ecological importance of the Sahyadri; (2) summarise the reported Saidongar project controversy; (3) examine the tree-protection principles in the Ajnyapatra; (4) explain the importance of Maharashtra's forts; and (5) propose a practical conservation and development framework.

The report is a desk-based review of public sources available as of 27 October 2026. It is not a legal opinion, an archaeological survey, or a full environmental impact assessment. Current project status and claims about permissions should be checked against official records. Historical comparisons are conceptual: similarity between principles does not establish that one country adopted another text.

3. The Sahyadri: A Living Ecological and Historical Landscape

The Sahyadri range forms part of the Western Ghats, a globally significant region for biodiversity. Forests provide habitat, hold soil on steep slopes, influence runoff, and support water systems and local livelihoods. Their loss can fragment habitats, increase erosion, alter drainage, and put pressure on communities that depend on the landscape.

Planting trees is valuable, but a new plantation does not instantly replace a mature natural forest. The age, diversity, structure, location, and ecological function of the original forest matter. Environmental review should consider not only the number of trees, but also species, wildlife movement, hydrology, slope stability, cumulative impacts, and realistic survival rates for replacement planting.

4. Case Study: Saidongar-1 and the Karjat Tree-Felling Controversy

Reports dated 24–27 October 2026 identify the project at the centre of the Karjat controversy as the Saidongar-1 pumped-storage project associated with Torrent Power, not Adani Group. The project is planned for 3,000 MW. News reporting described proposals affecting 233 hectares of forest land and the cutting of 32,490 trees; some project documents refer to a larger count when shrubs and other vegetation are included.

On 27 October 2026, The Times of India reported that tree felling had been halted amid protests, with officials saying there was no confirmed public decision at that time on whether cutting would resume. This is a time-specific update, not proof that the project itself was cancelled. The company and government have argued that the project will support energy needs and has received required clearances; local residents and environmental advocates have raised concerns about forest loss, consultation, water, biodiversity, and cumulative impacts.

The correct approach is to scrutinise evidence rather than repeat slogans. Relevant documents include the environmental clearance, forest-diversion approval, environmental impact assessment, public-hearing records, conditions attached to approvals, and monitoring reports. The public should be able to see what alternatives were assessed, how objections were answered, and how compliance will be independently verified.

The sources reviewed for this report do not establish that Adani Group owns or is developing Saidongar-1. Naming the correct project proponent is essential for fair and credible public discussion.

5. The Ajnyapatra: A Historical Principle of Responsible Resource Use

The Ajnyapatra (आज्ञापत्र) is a text on Maratha statecraft written around 1715–1716 by Ramchandrapant Amatya, traditionally understood as describing principles associated with Shivaji-era administration. It was not personally authored by Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj, although it reflects the political and administrative tradition linked with his rule.

A passage on naval timber explains that wood was necessary for ships, but valuable mango and jackfruit trees nurtured by local people should not simply be cut. It emphasises that trees take years to grow, that people care for them, and that causing grief or loss to subjects for a temporary gain is not sound governance. Where a privately owned tree genuinely needed to be cut, the passage describes obtaining the owner's consent and paying compensation rather than using force.

This is not a blanket prohibition on all tree cutting. It is a more practical principle: resource needs must be weighed against the time required for nature to recover, the value of trees to communities, and the legitimacy of the process. The lesson remains relevant: permission alone should not end public scrutiny, and the people who bear the cost of a project should not be treated as an afterthought.

6. Why Maharashtra's Historic Forts Matter

Maharashtra's forts preserve evidence of military engineering, political organisation, trade routes, water management, architecture, and everyday life. Their locations on hilltops, coastal edges, islands, and mountain passes show how geography shaped defence. Gates, ramparts, bastions, cisterns, temples, paths, and settlement remains form a connected heritage record.

On 11 July 2025, UNESCO inscribed the 'Maratha Military Landscapes of India' on the World Heritage List. The serial property includes 12 forts: 11 in Maharashtra and Gingee Fort in Tamil Nadu. The inscription recognises a wider military landscape, not merely isolated monuments. It increases the responsibility to conserve the forts' settings, routes, water systems, and relationships with the terrain.

Forts can support education, research, tourism, local employment, and community pride. But unplanned tourism can cause litter, traffic, erosion, vandalism, unsafe crowding, and damaging construction. Development should strengthen conservation rather than turn historic sites into commercial attractions that lose their authenticity.

7. Important Forts: Heritage and Conservation Priorities

Raigad Fort — closely associated with Shivaji Maharaj's coronation and the Maratha state. Priorities include managing visitor pressure, documenting historic structures, and protecting paths, water systems, and the landscape.

Shivneri Fort — traditionally identified as Shivaji Maharaj's birthplace. Interpretation should be historically grounded, while conservation should protect its fabric and improve safe access.

Rajgad Fort — an important early centre of the Maratha kingdom. Its scale, routes, and terrain demonstrate the strategic use of the mountain landscape.

Pratapgad Fort — associated with the 1659 encounter between Shivaji Maharaj and Afzal Khan. Interpretation should distinguish historical evidence from legend and protect the surrounding landscape.

Sindhudurg and Vijaydurg — coastal forts that demonstrate maritime defence and control of sea routes. Conservation must account for salt, waves, drainage, and coastal change.

Lohagad, Salher, Suvarnadurg, Khanderi, Panhala and other forts also deserve documentation and careful maintenance. The UNESCO-listed property includes a defined group of 12 forts; Maharashtra's wider fort heritage extends beyond that list.

8. What Responsible Fort Development Should Look Like

Fort development should mean conservation first, visitor facilities second, and commercial exploitation last. The aim is to make sites safer and more understandable without replacing historic fabric with new-looking reconstructions or damaging the surrounding landscape.

Recommended work includes: structural surveys of walls and gates; documentation before intervention; repairs using compatible materials under qualified conservation professionals; drainage and rainwater-system maintenance; clear signs and visitor maps; toilets, drinking water and waste facilities located away from sensitive archaeological areas; visitor limits at fragile sites; emergency plans for heavy rain, landslides, fire and crowding; and digital records using photography, mapping and 3D scanning.

Restoration does not mean rebuilding every ruin. Unsupported reconstruction can erase evidence of the past. Authorities should publish the purpose, evidence, methods, budget, contractor qualifications, and maintenance plan for conservation projects. Local residents should have opportunities to participate and benefit from responsible tourism.

9. A Practical Framework: Forests, Forts and Communities

First, map the whole landscape. Record forest boundaries, wildlife habitats, water catchments, village areas, historic structures, access routes, roads, and proposed infrastructure. Assess cumulative impacts rather than considering each project in isolation.

Second, publish decisions clearly. Make environmental assessments, clearance conditions, tree inventories, public-hearing records, restoration plans, and monitoring reports accessible in Marathi and English. Explain how objections were addressed.

Third, measure outcomes rather than promises. For tree planting, publish species, location, maintenance funding, survival targets, and independent survival audits. A planting target is not proof that lost forest has been fully replaced.

Fourth, make conservation a local economic opportunity. Train local guides, employ skilled craftspeople, support locally owned services, and direct an appropriate share of tourism revenue toward maintenance and community benefit.

Fifth, build a public monitoring system. Publish conservation budgets, work completed, site conditions, visitor numbers, complaints, and the agencies responsible. Encourage colleges and community groups to document conditions responsibly, without trespassing or disturbing wildlife.

10. Recommendations

1. Apply the Ajnyapatra's relevant lesson: consider long-term natural and social costs, not only immediate project benefits.

3. Require independent ecological assessment and transparent disclosure for major projects affecting forest landscapes.

4. Consult affected communities early and meaningfully, follow applicable law, and document how concerns are answered.

5. Treat mature forests as complex ecosystems, not simply as a count of individual trees that can be replaced immediately.

6. Give Maharashtra's forts regular maintenance funding, trained conservation staff, structural surveys, and site-specific management plans.

7. Avoid unverified reconstruction, intrusive commercial construction, and tourism practices that damage historic fabric.

8. Connect fort conservation with landscape protection, water management, disaster-risk planning, and local livelihoods.

9. Make project and conservation monitoring public, dated, and independently auditable.

10. Teach Maharashtra's history with evidence and pride: use primary sources, scholarly editions, official heritage records, and careful distinctions between fact, interpretation, and popular claims.

11. Conclusion

The Sahyadri forests and Maharashtra's forts are connected parts of a living inheritance. The forts show how Maratha strategy worked with the land; forests, water, routes, and terrain help

explain why these places mattered. Protecting heritage therefore means conserving more than stone walls, and responsible development means considering more than immediate economic output.

The Ajnyapatra offers a striking historical reminder that trees take time to grow, communities value them, and governance should not impose avoidable harm for temporary gain. Read carefully and in its historical context, it can inform present-day discussions about responsible resource use without suggesting that all tree cutting is forbidden.

The Saidongar controversy demonstrates the need for accurate facts, transparent process, ecological scrutiny, and community participation. The long-term goal should not be to reject every project or approve every project automatically. It should be to choose and design development that is justified by evidence, minimises irreversible harm, respects people, and protects Maharashtra's natural and historical legacy for future generations.

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